

« We were not making fluke jumps. It wasn't about performing well on just one day or in one season »

JAVIER SOTOMAYOR

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In a career that spanned three decades, Javier Sotomayor earned a place among the greatest high jumpers of all time, winning an Olympic gold, four World Championship titles, and setting the world record of 2.45m.

Speaking to *Sportstar* on the sidelines of the Ekamra Sports Literature Festival, the now 58-year-old reflected on taking up the high jump despite being afraid of heights, his never-ending chase for perfection, why his record still stands 32 years on, and why he is not sure he could break it if he were competing in the modern era.

You set your record in 1993. Thirty-two years later, it still stands. Why do you think that is?

I know how I broke the world record in 1993, but I can't explain why it has lasted so long. Competition played a role. I was fortunate to compete in what I believe was the best era of high jump. We were not making fluke jumps. It wasn't about performing well on just one day or in one season. We were jumping consistently at a

high level over multiple seasons.

The world record is 2.45m, and I didn't reach it suddenly. It was an evolution, and that comes from competing regularly against strong athletes. I was lucky to get the chance to compete against champion athletes from the time I was 16.

That is what pushed me constantly, and it helped me achieve the maximum that I could.

You also had a very unique technique.

Compared to most other jumpers, I had a very long final take-off step. For most people, the last step just before the jump is short, but mine was long because I was trying to combine two techniques, almost two types of jumpers, within myself. One who depended on speed, and the other who depended on the force generated at take-off.

I did that because I wanted to produce as much force as possible at the moment of jumping, which meant I had to generate maximum speed. That demanded a great deal of preparation, training, and stretching. Along with that came physical

therapy and constant jumping practice to ensure that my ankle stayed healthy. Even when I was off the track, I had to keep working on my ankle. Otherwise, I would have broken down quickly.

So I put a lot of effort into strengthening my ankles because there was always going to be heavy impact and a great deal of stress on that joint.

My technique was something I taught myself because it went against what the coaches expected. I stuck with it even when they wanted to change it. Theoretically, this was not the ideal way to jump, and initially, my trainer did not believe in it. But in the end, I convinced him that this was the way I wanted to jump.

Why do you think people haven't tried to duplicate your technique?

I think some people have tried to, but each athlete has to find the technique that works for him. Some depend on speed, while others generate a lot of force at the take-off point. My son also does the high jump. He is 17, but he is not competing at the highest level right now. I don't advise him to